Walking with Hall: Place, Interface, and Praxis at Play in the Stuart Hall Archive

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This paper introduces a locative literature project from the digital strand of the Stuart Hall Archive Project (SHAP; University of Birmingham, 2023-2026), 'Walking with Hall'. Stuart Hall was a founding figure in the field of cultural studies, a renowned and radical theorist of race, politics, and media. He served as director of the Centre for Contemporary Cultural Studies (CCCS) at the University of Birmingham from 1968-1979. The Stuart Hall Archive was deposited at the Cadbury Research Library (University of Birmingham) in 2018, indicating the importance of Birmingham to Hall's formation. 'Walking with Hall' was conceived as a new resource for increasing and broadening access to materials in the Stuart Hall Archive and narrativizing Hall's legacy, both on the University of Birmingham campus and beyond.

While there has been a significant push towards the digitisation of archival holdings over recent decades (Whaley 1994; Bell & Gray 1997; Wiedeman 2019), the total digitisation of such collections remains elusive. Further, significant digitisation efforts during this period have demonstrated that simply making materials digitally available is not enough to solve issues around the accessibility, discoverability, or useability of archival collections. Archives remain resources which can be difficult to find, navigate, and use by untrained and/or non-specialist audiences. Media theorist Trond Lundemo observed that 'the digital conversion [of archives] fundamentally changes not only the politics and priorities of the archive institutions, but also how one accesses and thinks about archival material' (Lundemo 2010) – a shift which requires researchers and practitioners to engage with media-specific analysis (Hayles 2002) and to consider the impact of mediation and digital interfaces.

With this in mind, the digital strand of SHAP has developed Walking with Hall, a place-based narrative featuring materials from the Stuart Hall Archive. Users access the piece via a mobile app that uses geo-location to unlock short pieces of text and other media as they navigate sites relating to the life and work of Stuart Hall. This method draws from previous studies of situated literature, including *Ambient Literature* (Abba, Dovey & Pullinger 2020) and the University of Southampton's 'Storyplaces' projects.

By immersing the user in a location-responsive narrative while they engage with Hall's work, Walking with Hall locates the archive and its histories in the world, creatively bringing materials out from the confinement of the physical archive. This provides a means by which publics can engage digitally with Hall's archive and legacy. The narrative aspect of Walking with Hall also serves as an aid to understanding the archive.

As an exercise in using new digital methods for archival representation, Walking with Hall explores the possibilities inherent in producing nonfictional location-responsive digital narratives that draw on archival material. This project therefore serves as a case study by which locative literature could be taken up as a way of providing access and engagement for other archival collections or in relation to other histories.

In considering the particularities of the Stuart Hall Archive, The Walking with Hall project applies Hall's work to the development of innovative digital methods for facilitating access to archives, using location-based narrative to creatively and critically think through how Hall's understanding of media and representation shape the way we mediate and represent the archive. This paper reports on the use of locative literature as an access point for the Stuart Hall archive, particularly focusing on the digital methods we have used and the critical frameworks through which we have developed the project. This includes a brief presentation of the app itself, and of a static, web-based version of the project which enables access for those who may not be ablet to visit the sites in-person or for whom installing the app version on a mobile device is an obstacle.

The pilot phase of Walking with Hall is now complete and so far focuses on sites around the University of Birmingham campus. This has established proof of concept regarding the use of locative literature to digitally mediate the archive. Further developments currently underway include new locations (including chapters based in the wider city of Birmingham, Oxford, and Jamaica), and additional features being added to the app (including more varied media types and additional material from the archive). The project is developing responsively not only through dialogues with a wide network of digital humanities and cultural studies scholars, but also with local communities.

Through a discussion of the project's methods, this paper details some of the key ways that locative literature offers a fruitful form through

which to explore the archive, including the rationale behind many of the design choices made along the way and how these relate to Hall's thinking about media, representation, and the way we occupy and perceive space – a few of which are briefly outlined below to demonstrate the conceptual inspiration for locative literature as a creative-critical digital output.

The project opens with an image of several photographs of Stuart Hall layered on top of one another, a nod to the quite literal framing of the multiplicity of the archive in line with Hall's own statement that 'I cannot become identical with myself' (Hall 2017).

One of the striking aspects of the history of the CCCS is its repeated displacement: over the course of Stuart Hall's tenure alone, the CCCS was at different times housed in various buildings on-campus, one building off-campus, and several temporary Quonset huts. Hall suggested that 'In case we had any doubts about our marginal status in the field, this physical displacement and the space in which we [the CCCS] operated symbolized it for us daily' (Hall 1990). This history of the CCCS – as being institutionally sidelined despite its lasting global and impact – is one uniquely accessed through Walking with Hall, through which a user is guided to visit each of the sites and reflect on the nature of each of the spaces that the CCCS occupied.

In navigating the University of Birmingham, Walking with Hall also highlights changes that have been made to the campus since the 1960s. For instance, the main library from Stuart Hall's time at the University, central to campus, was demolished in 2017. In designing Walking with Hall, we have considered Hall's correspondence on architecture in the archive, and in particular his comments on how buildings and communities co-constitute one another. We have presented the absence of the old library as a mediation of the University's community history, and as a haunting of the present campus. A future iteration of the project may include an augmented reality representation of the old library in the space it once occupied.

The final site discussed in this paper is the Great Hall, which is narrated in Walking with Hall in relation to the student occupation of this space and the Vice Chancellor's offices in 1968. The Stuart Hall Archive contains significant materials relating to the sit-in, including Hall's impassioned correspondence with students who were leading the widespread protests calling for a democratization of university structures in 1968 and his notes on and analysis of local newspaper reports on the protests. Walking with Hall utilises this material to think critically about – and to encourage users to think about – the mediation of space and institutional power structures.

My presentation of Walking with Hall in this paper demonstrates an innovative new way of digitally representing archives: in addition to practically engaging with Hall's work (for example on media and representation) in its design, this project provides digital access to archival materials, an aid to understanding elements of the archive through its narrativization of them, and a unique way of engaging local communities with Hall's legacy.

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